

Complete Guide to Italian Cooking

Chapter 1: Fresh Pasta Making

Making fresh pasta from scratch requires just two ingredients: flour and eggs. The ratio is typically 100 grams of flour to one large egg. Mix the flour into a well, add eggs, and gradually incorporate until a dough forms. Knead for 10 minutes until smooth and elastic.

Chapter 2: Classic Risotto

Risotto is a creamy Italian rice dish cooked with broth until it reaches a rich consistency. The key is Arborio or Carnaroli rice, which has high starch content. Toast the rice in butter, add warm broth one ladle at a time, stirring constantly for 18-20 minutes.

Chapter 3: Pizza Dough Fundamentals

Neapolitan pizza dough uses 00 flour, water, salt, and yeast. The hydration level should be 60-65%. Cold ferment the dough for 24-72 hours for best flavor development. Bake at the highest oven temperature (500F or higher) for 90-120 seconds.

Chapter 4: Essential Italian Sauces

The four mother sauces of Italian cooking are: Marinara (tomato, garlic, basil), Bolognese (meat, tomato, wine), Pesto (basil, pine nuts, parmesan, olive oil), and Alfredo (butter, parmesan, pasta water). Each sauce pairs best with specific pasta shapes.

Chapter 5: Wine Pairing Basics

Red wine pairs with hearty dishes like pasta Bolognese and grilled meats. White wine complements lighter fare such as seafood pasta and risotto. Italian wine regions produce excellent varieties: Chianti from Tuscany, Barolo from Piedmont, Prosecco from Veneto.

Essential Ingredients: Extra virgin olive oil, San Marzano tomatoes, fresh basil, Parmigiano-Reggiano, garlic, dried oregano